

PHUMELELA SPECIAL CARE CENTRE



OLD NKULULEKO BUILDING
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OUR BACKGROUND

Phumelela was founded in February 2005 by a group of concerned parents in Ezibeleni. They recognised the urgent need for proper care and support for children living with both physical and intellectual disabilities - needs that were not being met by existing facilities. These parents came together to create a safe and nurturing space where their children could learn, grow, and thrive.

The journey began in a small shack at the old Rent Office, caring for just three children. Despite the challenges - including poverty, unemployment, and limited resources—the centre gradually grew. In 2007, Phumelela relocated to its current site within a Department of Social Development building.

Today, the centre supports 127 learners, though only 40 are funded through the Department of Social Development. We rely heavily on generous donations from community members, churches, and local businesses. Thanks to this support, we can provide two nutritious meals each day and a variety of enrichment programmes.

OUR JOURNEY

Over the years, Phumelela Special Care Centre has built strong partnerships with local and international supporters, volunteers, and organisations:

- In 2006 and 2007, volunteers from Mozambique, Cape Town, and Canada supported the centre through a global exchange programme. They provided

training in HIV/AIDS awareness, home-based care, sports, proposal writing, and more.

- We partnered with Africare to deliver HIV and Orphans & Vulnerable Children (OVC) services for two years.
- Our learners have exhibited their beadwork at the Grahamstown Arts Festival and attended cultural events at venues like Lukhanji Town Hall and Macufe in Bloemfontein.
- Local churches have played a crucial role. The United Presbyterian Church of Southern Africa (UPCSA) and the Anglican Women's Fellowship (AWF) adopted the centre, supporting our learners and hosting community events.
- The Methodist Church's local preachers donated track tops, while the Methodist Young Women's Fellowship sponsored a festive outing to Berry Dam.
- We've received clothing and equipment donations from groups like Royal Capital, The Rep Newspaper, and the JZS Ncevu Youth Fellowship.
- In 2014, members of the England Presbyterian Women's Fellowship (EPWF) visited the centre.
- With support from St. Columbus Church, our ablution block was upgraded.
- In 2024, the National Lotteries Commission visited the centre to assess our facilities.
- For the 16 Days of Activism, we partnered with the Lisakhanya Project to take learners to key community sites including the fire station, museum, and library.

We also participated in Casual Day at Game stores, with support from Game and Wimpy. Rev. XX Vatela nominated Phumelela to collect donations at Edgars Nonesi Mall and Cathcart Road branches.

OUR CAPACITY BUILDING

- Ten caregivers received home-based care and first aid training from St John's Ambulance and later signed contracts under the Expanded Public Works Programme (EPWP).

- Eight beneficiaries received baking training in Keiskamahoe.
 - Two others completed ceramic and pottery training through Chris Hani Hub in Queenstown.
 - We also have a long-standing partnership with the Chris Hani Hub to support skills development and training.
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OUR INFRASTRUCTURE

Phumelela currently operates on land leased from the Department of Human Settlements under Lukhanji Municipality. In 2014, we signed a ten-year lease agreement, which allows the organisation to remain on the site under the condition that the name does not change.

OUR FUTURE PLAN

We are committed to growing and strengthening our services. Our plan of action includes:

- Applying for funding from various donors to sustain and expand our work.
- Requesting assistance from the Department of Public Works and Lukhanji Municipality for a purpose-built facility.
- Launching income-generating projects such as:
 - Bakery
 - Meat Processing
 - Milk, yoghurt, and jam production
 - Gardening
 - Sewing
 - Desk-making
 - Recycling & Upcycling
- Establishing a tuckshop managed by our beneficiaries to help them gain work experience and earn income.

- Recruiting and training more caregivers, especially local unemployed youth, to enhance the quality of care.

Phumelela Special Care Centre continues to grow as a beacon of hope for children with disabilities and their families in Ezibeleni and surrounding communities. We remain deeply rooted in compassion, community support, and the belief that every child deserves dignity, care, and the chance to thrive.

To help the Centre earn some income, we want to start small projects like gardening, sewing, making desks, and recycling. Over time, we hope to grow the Centre into a place that offers many different services and opportunities for the community.

We will look for more caregivers to join our team, especially young people who are not working. We will also provide them with training to improve the care and support we give.

Lastly, we plan to open a tuckshop that will be run by the people we support at the Centre. This will help them gain skills and earn an income.